

The Campus Coffee Map

Six competitors Dunkin' would face at River Campus — what they charge for a large iced latte and a large hot coffee, who already has a foothold on a college campus, and how students actually perceive them.

Client: Dunkin' **Location:** University of Rochester, River Campus **Date:** September 24, 2026

Starbucks, Peet's, and Connections Café — the three on-campus incumbents — are **team-verified prices** (in-person, September 2026). Tim Hortons, Dutch Bros, and McDonald's McCafé are marked **est.**, sourced from third-party menu aggregators, not a verified in-store or app price. Full source list in the companion speaker notes.

■ STARBUCKS

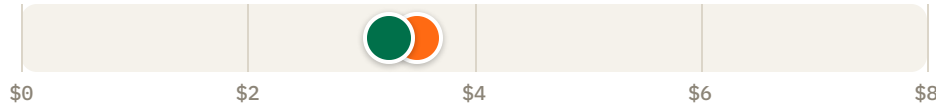
Starbucks

The incumbent premium anchor, already operating inside Wilson Commons.

Large Hot Coffee

Dunkin'

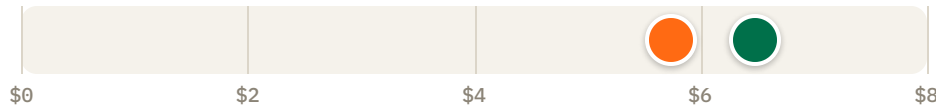
\$3.25



Large Iced Latte

Dunkin'

\$6.49



$\$6.05 + \$0.44 \text{ tax} = \$6.49 \text{ total}$. Hot coffee: \$3.25, no tax.

● This competitor ● Dunkin' (est., extrapolated from verified medium price)

COLLEGE PRESENCE

Operating today inside Wilson Commons on River Campus. Nationally, licensed Starbucks cafés are a standard fixture in university unions — the most common national campus coffee brand.

CONSUMER AWARENESS & PERCEPTION

Near-universal brand recognition and a "third place" study/social positioning. Mobile order + Starbucks Rewards drive habitual repeat visits. Frequently named by price-sensitive students as the expensive option.

WHY IT MATTERS FOR PRICING

Starbucks sets the familiar national-brand ceiling most students already expect — though Connections Café, next, actually prices higher still.

■ PEET'S COFFEE

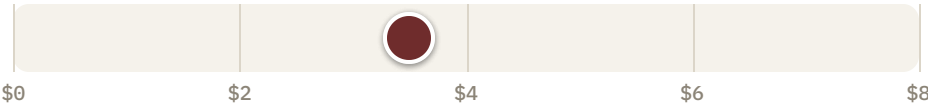
Peet's Coffee

The quieter incumbent, operating inside Wegmans Hall.

Large Hot Coffee

Dunkin'

\$3.50



Large Iced Latte

Dunkin'

\$6.00



● This competitor ● Dunkin' (est., extrapolated from verified medium price)

COLLEGE PRESENCE

Operating today inside Wegmans Hall on River Campus. Nationally a much smaller footprint than Starbucks, with far lower unaided brand awareness among students.

CONSUMER AWARENESS & PERCEPTION

Positioned on roast craft and quality rather than value. Lower brand recognition than Starbucks — some students may not register it as a distinct alternative at all.

WHY IT MATTERS FOR PRICING

Peet's proves two campus coffee options can coexist — but its lower visibility suggests awareness, not just price, drives share here.

■ CONNECTIONS CAFÉ

Connections Café

A third on-campus option — and the most expensive of the three.

Large Hot Coffee



Large Iced Latte



■ This competitor ■ Dunkin' (est., extrapolated from verified medium price)

Connections Café sells only one cup size (large) — both prices are all-inclusive of tax.

COLLEGE PRESENCE

Operating today on River Campus, alongside Starbucks and Peet's. Sells a single cup size — large only — so there is no smaller/cheaper option to trade down to.

CONSUMER AWARENESS & PERCEPTION

Not yet researched by the team — flag this as an open item. Worth asking surveyed students directly, since it lacks the national brand recognition Starbucks and Dunkin' both carry.

WHY IT MATTERS FOR PRICING

Connections is the most expensive on-campus incumbent by a wide margin — \$8.00 for a large iced latte, \$2 above Peet's and \$1.51 above Starbucks' total. That gives Dunkin' real room to undercut every on-campus option, not just match Starbucks.

 TIM HORTONS

Tim Hortons

The other "everyday value" coffee chain — and a proven campus operator.



COLLEGE PRESENCE

Real, documented on-campus locations at University at Buffalo — same region as Rochester — plus Carleton, Ottawa, Manitoba, UBC, and UTSC. UB named Tim Hortons the "Official Coffee of UB Athletics."

CONSUMER AWARENESS & PERCEPTION

Positioned squarely against Dunkin' as a value everyday-coffee brand. Regional strength grows closer to the Canadian border — a corridor Rochester sits within.

WHY IT MATTERS FOR PRICING

This is Dunkin's most direct positioning rival, and it already has a real campus foothold one region over.

■ DUTCH BROS

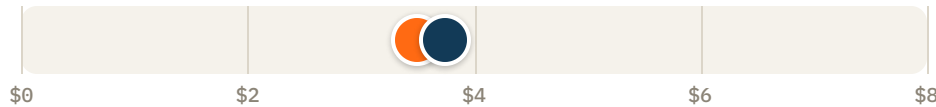
Dutch Bros Coffee

Drive-thru, not dine-in — but it wins the demographic Dunkin' needs.

Large Hot Coffee

Dunkin'

\$3.75 (est.)



Large Iced Latte

Dunkin'

\$6.75 (est.)



■ This competitor ● Dunkin' (est., extrapolated from verified medium price)

Wide regional range (\$3.50–\$7.50); figures shown are the range midpoint.

COLLEGE PRESENCE

Few if any true in-building campus locations, but drive-thru locations cluster near college towns — described in marketing research as a "campus must."

CONSUMER AWARENESS & PERCEPTION

80% of orders are customized. Strong TikTok/Instagram culture (2.3M+ #DutchBros views). Friendly "broista" service and a community-giving reputation drive loyalty specifically with under-25 customers.

WHY IT MATTERS FOR PRICING

Even without a campus location, Dutch Bros shows what wins Gen Z attention — customization and personality, not just price.

■ McCafé

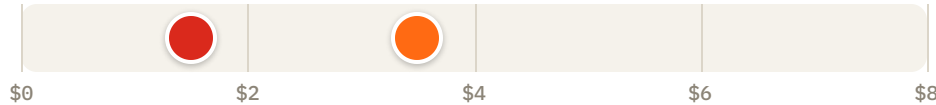
McDonald's McCafé

The price anchor everyone already knows.

Large Hot Coffee

Dunkin'

\$1.49 (est.)

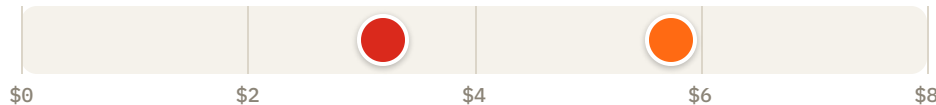


basic small/entry price — not itemized at large

Large Iced Latte

Dunkin'

\$3.19 (est.)



large iced coffee shown as a proxy — large iced latte price not found

● This competitor ● Dunkin' (est., extrapolated from verified medium price)

COLLEGE PRESENCE

Rarely on-campus, but a location is almost always within walking or driving distance of any campus. Explicitly marketed to budget-conscious young adults, including free-drink promotions for high school and college graduates.

CONSUMER AWARENESS & PERCEPTION

Seen as the reliable cheap fallback versus Starbucks and Dunkin'. Sets the psychological price floor for the whole category.

WHY IT MATTERS FOR PRICING

McCafé defines the bottom of the price range Dunkin' is competing across, even without being on campus.

A Large, Fragmented, Still-Growing Market

And the growth is coming from exactly the population on this campus.

\$58.5B

US branded coffee shop market, +4.2% last year

45,200+

outlets, across 588 unique brands

70–75%

of category revenue held by chains, not independents

66%

of US adults drank coffee yesterday

47%

had a specialty coffee drink yesterday — a record high

+30%

growth in coffee use among 18–26 year olds since 2020 — fastest of any age group

TAKEAWAY

Younger drinkers, not older ones, are the growth engine of this market right now — that's the demand-side case for entering at all.

Price Sensitivity Isn't Just About Age

01 BROAD TREND

Rising prices are pushing the general population toward home brewing and fewer shop visits (National Coffee Association, 2026).

02 COUNTERINTUITIVE FINDING

Some campus consumer-preference studies find full-time students report a *higher* willingness to pay and a larger self-reported coffee budget than working adults in the same study.

03 WHAT ACTUALLY DIFFERS

Not willingness to pay — it's what students are optimizing for. Frequency/habit and payment friction (dining dollars vs. cash) may matter as much as the sticker price itself.

IMPLICATION FOR DUNKIN'

A lower price alone may not decide this. Matching students' existing payment method — dining dollars — and building daily habit may matter just as much as beating Starbucks by 25 cents.